VOLUME-2

EPISODE-2

PAST JOINS US

You're the founder of this fucking organisation, but you don't really know what they're doing till now?

- ADAM TAYLOR (V.O.)

The Guardians weren't created for.the reasons you believe.

- ADAM TAYLOR (V.O.)

Everything is before your eyes.

- ADAM TAYLOR (V.O.)

You need to change your view.

- ADAM TAYLOR (V.O.)

Kat?

Kat?

Kat?

KATHERINE!

...What?

GUARDIANS SYNDICATE

Are you alright, Kat?

Yeah. I'm fine. Sorry. I was thinking about something.

Welcome back to the planet, Queen.

Very funny, Laks.

I thought so.

Alright. Let's get back to the numbers.

RECENT OPERATION REPORT

PREVIOUS OPERATIONS (AVG.)

28%

INFRASTRUCTURE DAMAGE

LAST OPERATION

13%

INFRASTRUCTURE DAMAGE

We've managed to reduce the damage compared to the previous months. The last operation ended with thirteen percent local infrastructure damage.

It's still more than I'd like, but it's progress. We're getting better at containing fights before they spread.

Progress is worth acknowledging. But we shouldn't mistake improvement for perfection.

Agreed.

ASHTON - SECURITY OVERVIEW

DARK CITY

The restrictions along the Dark City borders stay in place. No unauthorized movement, no unapproved transactions, and no loopholes.

BORDER RESTRICTIONS

NO UNAUTHORIZED MOVEMENT

NO UNAPPROVED TRANSACTIONS

INCREASED SURVEILLANCE

ALL CHECKPOINTS ACTIVE

And if someone finds one?

We close...

The numbers are improving. But if someone is still finding ways around our security, we need to know how.

I'll review the reports again. There may be a pattern we missed.

Good. Don't just look at the incidents. Look at what connects them.

Keep monitoring the borders, continue the repair work, and send me anything unusual. We meet again once we've got the updated reports.

Understood.

GUARDIANS SYNDICATE

Kat.

Hmm?

GUARDIANS SYNDICATE

Come on. I've known you for more than a decade. You've been somewhere else since this meeting started. And you're terrible at pretending otherwise.

I am not.

Kat, you just stared at the same wall for ten minutes.

It was a very interesting wall.

Right. I'll ask the wall what it told you.

You're such a nerd.

And yet, you keep me around.

Someone has to make sure you don't destroy the city.

I've reduced the damage to thirteen percent. Show some respect.

You know you can tell me if something's bothering you.

I know.

Good. Because I'm not leaving. until you stop looking like you've seen a ghost.

You're not leaving?

Not until you tell me whether the wall said anything else.

What did Taylor say to you?

Oh. Even you know?

If you're this confused, you definitely met that bearded guy.

How can someone I've known for more than a decade do something like this?

And what do you think? Is he really a bad person?

Who am I to say anything? The court has already ruled against him. Every piece of evidence points towards him.

So, yeah. I guess he's guilty.

So, if every piece of evidence was against me...

If everyone said I was on the wrong side, that I was working with the bad guys...

But I told you I wasn't. Would you believe me? Or you would oppose me?

Kat, what are you—

Just answer the question, Alpha.

Yeah... even the people closest to you can lose their trust in you before you even—

When I opened my eyes in that dark laboratory...

There were scientists, doctors, surgeons, researchers... so many people around me.

I didn't know what was happening around me.

I didn't know what was happening inside me, either. I didn't know who those people were, what they wanted from me... or why I was there.

Then they shifted me into another room.

And there was one person standing in the middle of that room.

When I looked at her...

She was the only person in that room I felt I could trust.

That woman was you, Kat.

And from that day until this one... I've believed in you.

So you're asking whether I'd trust you if everyone turned against you?

Bullshit.

Who else am I supposed to trust?

GUARDIANS SYNDICATE

Hey...

Whatever's going on inside that head of yours, Kat... you don't have to explain it to me.

Try to work through it yourself. Whatever it is, it's yours to figure out.

Only you can find the answer you're looking for.

Since when did you start giving motivational speeches, you big man?

When my friend is feeling low, I become a shoulder to lean on.

Anything for my Queen.

You're impossible.

Nothing is impossible.

Ahn Ahn.

Alright. I should get going.

Already?

Unless you want another thirty-minute lecture on friendship and emotions I support.

Absolutely not.

Good. I was running out of material.

Remember something, Kat.

Even if you were on the wrong side... even if everyone turned against you...

If you turned around, I'd be there.

Keep that in mind.

-ADAM TAYLOR (V.O.)
"Everything is before your eyes."

-ADAM TAYLOR (V.O.)
"Everything is before your eyes..."

GUARDIANS SYNDICATE

-ADAM TAYLOR (V.O.)
"You need to change your view."

Now i know where to start the search.

MANDICE

MANDICE

Are you always this serious?

Only when people ask me strange questions.

You never listen!

I listened. I just disagreed.

That's even worse!

Even their smallest disagreements became memories worth keeping.

Mandice was a nice girl.

You introduced her to me two years ago, remember?

...

Yeah.

When she first met me, she barely tried to talk about anything else.

Instead, she asked me about my experience with love.

She was eager to hear everything I had to say. Every little thing.

She wanted to understand love that much.

That tells you how much she loved you.

You can drench yourself in love.

Not in the rain. Here, take it.

That was terrible.

You're welcome.

MANDICE

I met the woman I loved during the First World War.

France. Everywhere I looked, people were trying to survive.

Everyone was trying to survive the war. But she kept opening her home to people who had nowhere else to go.

I had been sent there to destroy the French army from within.

That was my mission.

But when I saw what she was doing... I began to question everything I'd been ordered to do.

I betrayed my own army.

Not because I suddenly understood the world.

Because she showed me something I'd stopped looking for.

At first, she was surprised by the way I looked.

But eventually, she saw someone who could help end the war.

She trusted me in a way nobody else had.

She saw something in me that nobody had bothered to look for.

Sometimes, there's someone who sees you differently from everyone else.

Someone who sees the person you could be, even when the rest of the world sees something else.

Mandice saw that in you, too.

We lived together for almost forty years.

She was human. I knew from the beginning that she couldn't live as long as I could.

She grew older.
Her body grew weaker.

She died of old age, peacefully, in my arms.

She wanted children.

But with someone like me, that was never going to happen.

She never blamed me for it.
Never made me feel like I had failed her.

She loved me more than I ever knew how to explain.

When she died, I was a completely different man.

I eventually moved to India.

That's where I met the man who changed my ideology... and helped change the way I saw the world.

Everything that happened to me brought me to where I am now.

Listen, mate.

Moving on doesn't mean you stop loving her. It doesn't mean you leave her behind.

It means you keep living, even with the part of you that misses her.

I believe you'll find your way through this. You just need to keep moving.

But... you still have her in your heart, right?

...

...

Yeah.

MANDICE

Moving forward doesn't mean leaving love behind.
Sometimes, it means learning to carry it into the light.

MANDICE


WORK
SURVIVE
REPEAT
DARK CITY
INDUSTRIAL DISTRICT


You raised it last month! I have two children!
Rent's gone up again.
Then find somewhere cheaper.




Skipper!
That joint needs to hold. We're already behind schedule!
It'll hold.








Every day.
Then why don't you?
Ever think about leaving this place?
Because thinking about leaving doesn't pay the bills.


Can you finish it today?
If you stop asking me every five minutes, maybe.


CITY IN CHAOS
HERO CONTAINS DISASTER


He walked away.
After everything he did, he walked away.
I'll make sure he doesn't walk away from me.




There you are.


...Ahhh, him again?
Hello, Skipper.

You shouldn't be here.

That's a terrible way to greet an old acquaintance.

We're not acquaintances.

Oh, come on. We've both working for the same people.

I never wanted to work with anyone like you.

Steel beams. Concrete floors. Hundreds of people going home at the end of the day, believing the roof over their heads will still be there tomorrow.

Beautiful, isn't it? All this work just to keep the world standing.

What do you want?

A team.

Find someone else.

I haven't even told you what we're going to do.

I don't need to know.

You could disappear. Change your name. Move somewhere else. Build another life.

And how long before your people find me?

...

I know the answer.

Still hurts?

It works.

That's not what I asked.

And I didn't ask you to come here.

Whatever you're planning, leave these people out of it.

These people? You think they matter to the ones running this city?

They matter to me.

That's your problem, Skipper.

You still think caring about people makes you different from the rest of us.

It does.

I almost envy you.

CHILLTANK'S GARAGE.

You have a lot of nerve coming here.

And you have a very expensive habit of breaking things.

Get to the point.

I've heard you've been looking for a way to get back at Alpha.

Who told you that?

Your face does.

You don't know anything about me.

I know you want him dead.

I don't want someone else to do it. I don't want to watch him fall on a screen.

I want him in front of me.

I want him to know who's standing there when he finally goes down.

And what happens when you get your chance?

I'll kill him with my own hands.

Then perhaps we can help each other.

I don't take orders from you.

Wonderful.

I hate giving them.

CONSTRUCTION SITE. EVENING.

You're a good man, Skipper.

Don't pretend you know me.

I don't need to know you. I only need to know what you're afraid of losing.

If I refuse, what happens?

You'll go back to work tomorrow. You'll weld your beams, collect your wages, buy food for your family, and tell yourself you're staying out of trouble.

And you'll spend every day wondering when someone come looking for you and knock your door.

Site's closing! Pack up!

I won't hurt innocent people.

And I won't kill anyone just because you tell me to.

I didn't ask you to.

We'll see how long that lasts.

CHILLTANK'S GARAGE. LATER.

You're joining him?

I don't have much of a choice.

There's always a choice.

Easy to say when the only thing you care about is revenge.

This is not something we work with toys Skipper.

Look at you two. One wants to protect what he has. The other wants to destroy the man who took something from him.

Different reasons. Same destination.

Don't compare us.

Why not? Neither of you believes the Guardians will give you what you want.

The Guardians have their headquarters. Their uniforms. Their speeches about justice.

We are going to have that too.

And I intend to make them look at every single one.

Who are the others?

I will find them soon.

Who you have in your mind?

Someone who is ready to kill.

B1
B5
B10
B20
B30
B40
B50
B60
???
DING.
K-CHUNK.
GUARDIANS
SYNDICATE
Guardians Syndicate Headquarters — Underground Library.
ADAM TAYLOR (V.O.)
"Everything is before your eyes."
ARCHIVED PERSONNEL RECORD
SUBJECT : ALPHA
CLASSIFICATION : RESTRICTED
LABORATORY RECORDS : MULTIPLE ENTRIES FOUND
PRE-LABORATORY HISTORY : ACCESS LIMITED
Access limited?
LABORATORY OBSERVATION REPORT
SUBJECT: ALPHA
Where's the rest of it?
ALPHA
MEDICAL ASSESSMENT
ALPHA
LABORATORY OBSERVATION
ALPHA
PERSONNEL BACKGROUND
That's not possible.
LAKS
PERSONNEL RECORD
Family
Childhood
Education
Early Life
Notes
ATOM GIRL
PERSONNEL RECORD
Family
Childhood
Education
Early Life
Notes
Everyone has a past documented here...
ALPHA
PERSONNEL RECORD
PRE-LABORATORY LIFE
Childhood : —
Family : —
Education : —
Early Life : —
Everyone... except Alpha.
Twenty years of records... and not one of them tells me who he was before the laboratory?
Someone didn't just lose his history.
Someone made sure it wasn't here.
1337
1337
1338
1339
R-401
R-402
R-402
R-403
R-404
R-405
Ma'am?
Is everything alright?

I noticed several archive requests being opened simultaneously. Do you need assistance finding anything mam?

I'm reviewing some old personnel records.

Would you like me to retrieve the relevant files?

No, thank you. I need to compare the original reports myself.

You can return to your duties. I'll call if I need anything.

Of course, ma'am.

A-112 B-204 C-317 D-402

RESTRICTED

CLICK.

CLACK.

DENIED.

CLUNK.

Come on...

K-CHUNK.

What is this place?

THUNK.

RESTRICTED
EXECUTIVE AUTHORIZATION REQUIRED

CONFIDENTIAL

BOSSMODE

RESTRICTED
PERSONNEL INTELLIGENCE

Sir, one more! This time, make your arm longer!

Longer? At this rate, I'll need to charge you people by the metre.

How is that even possible?

Good genes, terrible posture.

Seriously?

No. But you already took the photo, so now it's too late.

Teacher! It's Shape Shifter!

Can we take a photo with him?

Excuse me, Laks. Would you mind taking a photograph with my students?

Mind? I've been waiting all day for my most important fans.

Alright, before we begin, I need to know something. Who here is the bravest?

Wow. That's a very competitive classroom.

Really? Then tell me, are you scared of monsters?

I'm the bravest!

No!

Spiders?

No!

Your teacher when she says there's homework?

Okay, maybe a little!

An honest answer. I respect that.

Congratulations. You've all passed the bravery test.

But you only asked her!

That's because I know your answer.

Alright, everyone! Nobody moves, nobody blinks, and absolutely nobody steals my spotlight.

You're not even in the middle!

Exactly. I'm making room for the stars.

Everyone, *look here!*

CHEESE!

CLICK!

You definitely have a great fanbase among kids.

Hey! Bunker? Right.

That's my father's surname. You can call me Kroos.

Right. Kroos Bunker.

See? You got it eventually.

So, what brings you here? Taking a break from saving lives?

Something like that. I was passing through.

Good timing. You missed the part where I signed an autograph on someone's lunchbox.

Tragic. I'll try to arrive earlier next time.

Do you live around here?
Not far away.
Nice. So you don't have to travel across the entire city every time someone needs a doctor.
Thankfully, no.
What about your family?
Yes. I've got a lovely wife and a son.
Ah, a family man!
I'd say I'm a lucky man.
Being a doctor keeps me busy enough. But coming home to them makes everything worthwhile.
That's nice, man. Really.
What about you other than I know about you from comics and moviee? What do you do when you're not saving the city or entertaining half of Ashton?
Depends on the day. Sometimes I fix things. Sometimes I break things. Usually I try to make sure I don't have to fix what I break.
An interesting professional strategy.
I call it job security.
Actually, I've been doing some research into mutant genetics.
I'm interested in understanding how these abilities work. How they affect the body, how people adapt to them... things like that.
Sounds complicated.
It can be.
Can I ask you something about your ability?
Sure. As long as you're not planning to turn me into a lab rat.
Nothing like that. When you stretch your body, does it feel different from normal movement?
At first, it was painful. Really painful.
Everything felt strange. Like my body wasn't supposed to move the way I wanted it to.
But you get used to it. After a while, it becomes normal.
Like walking, running, or picking something up. You don't think about every little movement. You just do it.
Then when did you first realize you had this ability? Do you remember the exact moment your body first started stretching?
I mean...
I don't know.
I don't remember that part.
One day, I just realized my body could stretch. Then I started learning how to control it.
That's it. Nothing more than that.
Alright.
Thanks for answering.
We'll meet again soon, buddy.
Next week, right?
Maybe before that, too.
Shape Shifter! Can I have your signature?
One more photo!
Alright, alright! One at a time. Even superheroes need a queue!

BOSSMODE
RESTRICTED
PERSONNEL INTELLIGENCE
BELLY MAN
INCIDENT REPORT
RESTRICTED

Belly Man?
Why would his report be kept here?

GUARDIANS SYNDICATE
INTERNAL INCIDENT REPORT
SUBJECT: BELLY MAN
STATUS: DECEASED
CASE CLASSIFICATION: RESTRICTED
[redacted]
CAUSE OF DEATH:
TOXICOLOGICAL EXPOSURE

POST-MORTEM EXAMINATION
- Severe pulmonary tissue injury consistent with acute toxic inhalation.
- Residue analysis indicates exposure to phosphine gas (PH_3).
- Concentration detected: sufficient to cause fatal respiratory and systemic toxicity.

Phosphine...?

TOXICOLOGY ANALYSIS (Continued)
Detected Compound:
Phosphine (PH_3)
Chemical Formula: PH_3
Exposure Route: Inhalation
Tissue Concentration: Fatal Range
KNOWN INTERNAL INVENTORY MATCH:
ASHTON RESEARCH LABORATORY
SOURCE CONFIRMATION: PENDING / RESTRICTED
[redacted]
CONFIDENTIAL

No...
FLAP
FLAP
THUD

Why would a chemical from an Ashton laboratory be connected to his death?

Was this an accident...?
Or did someone make sure it looked like one?

MGen83'
CHEMICAL RESEARCH DIVISION
Date: 1974
RESTRICTED

MGen... eighty-three?
MGen83'
Is this any chemical?

CHEMICAL RESEARCH DIVISION
ARCHIVED TECHNICAL REPORT
COMPOUND DESIGNATION: MGen83'
DOCUMENT DATE: 1974
RESEARCH STATUS: HISTORICAL / RESTRICTED
[redacted]

MGen83'
[redacted]
- Observed interaction with host genetic material...
- Abnormal cellular response under controlled exposure...
- Altered expression of selected biological markers...
- Results vary according to host condition and dosage...
[redacted]

PRELIMINARY TOXICOLOGICAL ASSESSMENT
- Exposure may induce widespread cellular instability.
- Normal cellular function may be disrupted by unregulated genetic interaction.
- Elevated risk of tissue damage and systemic failure. observed in non-responsive subjects.
[redacted]

RECONSTRUCTING MISSING PAGE...

An engineered compound intended to alter the host's genetic response...

Induce a controlled biological deviation...

MGen83'
Chemical Research Division

But the majority of early trials produced cellular rejection.

EARLY EXPERIMENTAL RESULTS



Pulmonary tissue degeneration



Abnormal cellular structure



HOST NON-RESPONSE
TERMINAL COMPLICATIONS

The compound cannot be considered viable in its present formulation.

PREVIOUS FORMULATIONS

Compound ID	Year	Result	Notes
MGen01	1920	FAILED	Severe rejection
MGen17	1927	UNSTABLE	High toxicity –
MGen32	1944	FAILED	Cellular collapse
MGen61	1963	DISCONTINUED	Unstable genetic interaction
MGen77	1988	FAILED	Immune response
MGen83'	1974	PROCEED (Restricted)	Shows potential (for genetic alteration)

These weren't isolated experiments...

They kept changing it.

Formulation revision required.

Investigate whether the compound may be refined through engineered modification of the precursor formulation.

Objective: improved host compatibility and sustained genetic alteration.

PROJECT: MUTA—

Project Mutation?

PROJECT MUTATION

Project Mutation...!

MGen83' — DEVELOPMENT SUMMARY

First documented formulation to demonstrate reproducible genetic alteration in selected test subjects under controlled conditions.

Further refinement required.

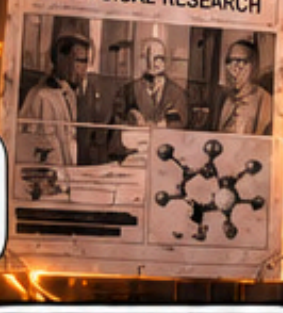
Long-term host stability remains under evaluation.

SUCCESSFUL INDUCTION

They weren't just studying chemicals...

They were trying to change what a human being is.

1920
PRELIMINARY BIOLOGICAL RESEARCH



1927
CHEMICAL FORMULATION TRIALS



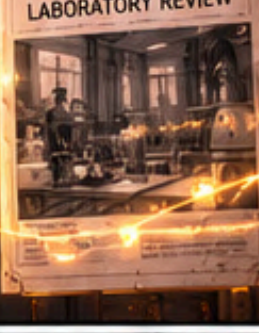
1944
HOST RESPONSE OBSERVATIONS



1988
GENETIC MODIFICATION STUDY



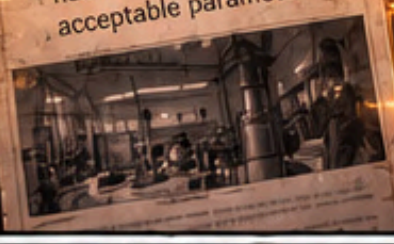
2000
RESTRICTED LABORATORY REVIEW



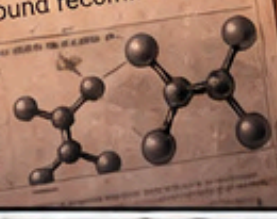
1920
Genetic response remains inconsistent.



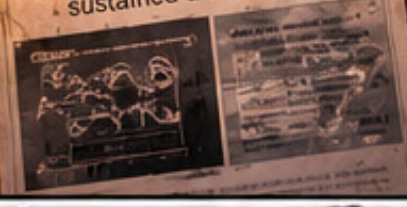
1927
Host compatibility has not reached acceptable parameters.



1944
Further modification of the precursor compound recommended.



1988
Subject response indicates potential for sustained alteration.



Decades of research...
Decades of revisions...
Decades of secrets...

BOSSMODE

BELLY MAN
INCIDENT REPORT
REDACTED

What have you done...

Mutations are...?

Really, this place is way more silent than the rest of the city. And it's beautiful.

Of course it is. I found it.

Whenever I need to write an article, I come here. No noise, no interruptions, nobody disturbing me. It's perfect for working alone.

And yet, today, you brought me.

Don't make me regret it, Mister.

So, how many secret places do you have?

Enough that I'm not telling you about the others.

That's unfair.

Life's unfair. Write an article about it.

Okay. My turn now. I need to show you a place.

Where?

No. Absolutely not.

Trust me?

That question has never made me feel safer.

OH, MY GOD! OH, MY GOD!

I'm not going to drop you, Amy. Don't be scared.

I'M PRAYING TO ALL SEVEN GODS RIGHT NOW!

All seven? You really don't trust me.

YOU'RE FLYING!

We're here.

This is where I come when I feel low.

From up here, everything seems a little smaller. Even the things that feel impossible down there.

The destination was beautiful.

The travel experience was terrible.

I'll improve my service next time.

I will never have your service next time!

You know, I'm right here. You can let go.

I'm aware. I'm choosing not to.

When I was seven, my father took me somewhere a little like this.

Not this high, obviously.

He wasn't trying to give me a heart attack.

Whenever things got too loud, he'd take me somewhere quiet. He'd tell me the world was much bigger than whatever problem I was worrying about.

At seven, I thought he knew everything. Now I know he was making half of it up.

But tis worked. I guess that's why I became a reporter. I wanted to understand the world he kept telling me was so big.

What about you?

I don't have anyone.

My past starts in a laboratory. Scientists, doctors, machines.

That's as far back as I can remember.

So, no interesting childhood stories from me. You'll have to continue yours.

I'm interested in your story.

You're a hero, Rogers. You've saved thousands of people.

Don't tell me there's nothing worth knowing about you.

Ah, I tried searching for my past before the laboratory.

But every time I went further, my present became harder to deal with.

Eventually, I just stopped looking.

How can someone live without knowing their own memories?

Let me ask you something. If you had two choices — erase every memory of your past, or never make another new memory for the rest of your life, which would you choose?

...

That's me, Amy. If I keep digging into my past, I might lose the person I've become. I might lose the time I still have to live this life.

So I leave it where it is. And I try to make the memories I can still have.

For someone who claims he has no stories, you just gave me the most depressing answer I've heard all week.

You're a reporter. I thought you liked depressing stories.

Only when someone else has to write them.

So, what would you have chosen?

I'm not telling you.

Why?

Because you'll turn it into another philosophical question.

What, I have never done that.

You literally just did.

QUEEN?!

Kat?

Sorry for disturbing you both.

But, Alpha, you need to see this. Now.

TO BE CONTINUED...